

Work at Height SOP

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1. Purpose

This SOP establishes the requirements for planning and safely performing any work carried out at a height where a fall could cause personal injury, including work on ladders, scaffolding, elevated platforms, rooftops, and mezzanine structures. Falls from height remain among the most common causes of serious and fatal workplace injury, and this procedure sets out the hierarchy of controls to eliminate or minimize that risk.

2. Scope

Applies to any task performed at a height of 1.8 meters or more above a lower level, or any task at a lower height with an increased risk of injury (e.g., work over machinery, open pits, or water). Covers employees, contractors, and any third party performing elevated work at the facility.

3. Hierarchy of Controls

- Avoidance: eliminate the need to work at height wherever possible, for example by using extendable tools from ground level or pre-assembling components before lifting.
- Collective Protection: use guardrails, scaffolding with edge protection, or elevated work platforms (EWPs) that protect all workers in the area without requiring individual action.
- Personal Fall Protection: where collective protection is not practicable, use a full-body harness with a shock-absorbing lanyard connected to an engineered anchor point rated for fall-arrest loads.
- Fall Restraint vs Fall Arrest: prefer restraint systems that physically prevent a worker from reaching a fall edge over arrest systems that stop a fall already in progress, wherever the task allows.

4. Permit to Work

All work at height above 1.8 meters requires an approved Work-at-Height Permit issued by the area supervisor after review of the task risk assessment, equipment inspection records, and weather conditions. The permit specifies the approved access equipment, fall protection system, rescue plan, and validity period, and must be displayed at the work location.

5. Equipment Requirements

- Ladders must be inspected before use for damage, correct footing, and secure positioning at the correct angle (approximately 75 degrees, or a 1:4 ratio); metal ladders are prohibited near electrical hazards.
- Scaffolding must be erected and inspected only by a certified scaffolder, tagged with a current inspection tag (green for safe, red for unsafe), and re-inspected after any weather event or modification.
- Full-body harnesses and lanyards must be inspected before each use for fraying, cuts, stitching damage, and functioning buckles/hooks, and must be certified to IS 3521 / EN 361 or equivalent standard.

- Anchor points for fall-arrest systems must be engineered and rated for the required load; improvised anchor points (e.g., pipework, handrails not rated for the purpose) are prohibited.
- Elevated work platforms (scissor lifts, boom lifts) must only be operated by certified operators, with the harness lanyard attached to the manufacturer-designated anchor point inside the basket.

6. Weather and Environmental Conditions

Work at height must be suspended during high winds, lightning, heavy rain, or any condition that compromises stability or visibility, as defined by site-specific thresholds in the Work-at-Height Permit. Supervisors must monitor conditions throughout the task and halt work immediately if conditions deteriorate beyond the specified limits.

7. Rescue Planning

No work-at-height activity using personal fall-arrest equipment may begin without a pre-planned rescue procedure capable of retrieving a suspended worker within the medically recommended window to avoid suspension trauma, generally within 10 to 15 minutes. Rescue equipment must be present at the work site and personnel trained in its use before work commences.

8. Exclusion Zones and Ground Protection

Barricades and warning signage must be established at ground level beneath any elevated work area to prevent personnel from entering the zone at risk from falling tools or materials. Tools and materials used at height must be secured with tool lanyards or carried in closed-top containers to prevent them from falling.

9. Training and Medical Fitness

All personnel performing work at height must complete certified work-at-height training covering hazard recognition, correct use of fall protection equipment, and rescue awareness, with recertification every 2 years. Employees must also pass a medical fitness assessment confirming no conditions (such as vertigo or cardiac conditions) that would increase risk while working at height, repeated annually or as directed by the occupational health physician.